to get out quickly enough. The sight of so many now so eager to enter the country has been a source of both puzzlement and pride to the Irish – at least that was the case then. It was taking place in a society that was not really used to foreigners but also in one that – as I will try to show later on – shares some of the features with the societies of Eastern Europe.

It does not, therefore, come as a great surprise that Ireland (even before the 2008 recession hit the world) soon became perplexed about whether it was indeed a good idea to have workers from the new member states allowed in without work-permits. Initially, there was a general consensus that they had been a good thing for the Irish economy: they had mostly taken jobs as construction workers, grocery shop assistants, or waiters and maids – jobs that are usually not particularly attractive to the 'natives'. But following some controversial cases, people began to wonder if workers from so-called Eastern Europe were indeed taking Irish jobs – despite the continued decline in unemployment.

It also soon became obvious that the lack of understanding of Eastern Europe and Eastern Europeans was becoming an issue. Even those – and they are the majority in Ireland – who do respect the dignity of immigrants have sometimes spoken about workers from Eastern Europe as if they were from an entirely different culture and required nothing less than an introduction to the ways of Europe. The rise of what today is seen as socially conservative policies and populism in Central and Eastern Europe has revived the need for such an introduction.

The issue of 'Eastern Europeans' in Ireland at the time had prompted me to start thinking about what it is that makes me feel European and why I – then a young diplomat in Ireland – am not comfortable with the label Eastern European, at least not when it is used, as it so often is, to imply a *Lesser* European. In fact, I had often felt like I woke up to a new world in 1990, when people in Western Europe started to call us by this uninspiring name – Eastern Europeans. As a famous Slovenian writer commented, Eastern Europe was created (again) with the European Enlargement Day of 2004. And the more we keep saying that this is not our name, the more it seems to be used.

Was I over-sensitive? A reviewer of the first edition of this book thought so and recommended that I should get over it, and accept the term Eastern Europe, then (as now) a common expression for the geopolitical region.